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SECURITY



UK government wants
ransomware victims to
report breaches so it can
carry out ‘targeted
disruptions’ against
hackers

The U.K. government wants to require victims of ransomware to report if they were breached with the goal of providing law enforcement with information that could help target the cybercriminals responsible.

On Tuesday, the U.K.'s interior ministry, the Home Office, [published a proposal](#) with the aim of changing the British government's strategy to counter ransomware. Among the three key proposals is a reporting requirement, which would aid authorities in identifying and disrupting hacking operations.

IMAGE CREDITS:

AARON CHOWIN/PA IMAGES / GETTY IMAGES

“Mandatory reporting is also being developed, which would equip law enforcement with essential intelligence to hunt down perpetrators and disrupt their activities, allowing for better support for victims,” read the proposal.

In [its proposal](#), the U.K. government said the mandatory reporting requirement would allow the government to “engage in targeted disruptions in an evolving threat landscape.”

The other two key proposals include a ban on paying ransomware for public sector and critical infrastructure organizations, and a mandate to notify the government if other types of victim organizations intend to pay a hacker's ransom.

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Ransomware investigators applauded the proposals, in particular the efforts focusing on helping law enforcement.

“I think it is a tacit acknowledgment of what we’ve known for a while: Ransomware operators and their enablers are not confined to Russia and many of those involved are very catchable and, more importantly, prosecutable,” Allan Liska, a threat intelligence analyst and ransomware expert at cybersecurity firm Recorded Future. “I think it’s super important.”

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Arda Büyükkaya, a senior cyber threat intelligence analyst at EclecticIQ, applauded the proposals for making “things official.”

“While it’s unclear whether everything will unfold exactly as written, we’ll see through future developments,” Büyükkaya told TechCrunch. “Overall, banning ransom payments and actively pursuing perpetrators is a strong deterrent and helps impose real costs on threat actors.”

Tuesday's announcement is the latest in [a policy consultation process that began in January](#), in which the Home Office [initially introduced](#) the three key policy changes. The U.K. government's formal response to the consultation is another step toward amending the law, but it remains to be seen if the proposals will end up being enshrined in legislation.

Banning ransomware payments [is a controversial idea](#). For some, banning payments to hackers is an obvious way to stop criminal gangs profiting from cyberattacks and extorting victims. But some argue that, occasionally, paying a ransom may be the only viable option to recover critical systems and get back online, especially for certain critical industries, such as hospitals, which cannot afford the downtime and the very real risks to patients' health.

Earlier this year, [Australia enacted a law](#) to mandate ransomware victims to disclose if they paid the hackers, stopping short of banning payments.

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IMAGE CREDITS:

HUNTERS INTERNATIONAL (SCREENSHOT)

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Ransomware gang Hunters International says it's shutting down

Lorenzo Franceschi-
Bicchierai

— 7:45 AM PDT · July 3,
2025

The ransomware gang known as Hunters International announced on its dark web page Thursday that it is shutting down.

“After careful consideration and in light of recent developments, we have decided to close the Hunters International project,” the hackers wrote in a post, without clarifying what specific developments it was referring to. “This decision was not made lightly, and we recognize the impact it has on the organizations we have interacted with.”

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The hackers also said they are offering free decryption keys “to all companies that have been impacted by our ransomware.”

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Project Closure and Free Decryption Software for Affected Companies

We, at Hunters International, wish to inform you of a significant decision regarding our operations. After careful consideration and in light of recent developments, we have decided to close the Hunters International project. This decision was not made lightly, and we recognize the impact it has on the organizations we have interacted with.

As a gesture of goodwill and to assist those affected by our previous activities, we are offering free decryption software to all companies that have been impacted by our ransomware. Our goal is to ensure that you can recover your encrypted data without the burden of paying ransoms.

We understand the challenges that ransomware attacks pose, and we hope that this initiative will help you regain access to your critical information swiftly and efficiently. To access the decryption tools and receive guidance on the recovery process, please visit our official website.

We appreciate your understanding and cooperation during this transition. Our commitment to supporting affected organizations remains our priority as we conclude our operations.

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THE HUNTERS INTERNATIONAL POST ANNOUNCING IT IS SHUTTING DOWN.

IMAGE CREDITS:HUNTERS INTERNATIONAL (SCREENSHOT)

Several ransomware gangs in the past have released their victims’ decryption keys, then shut down, each of them for different reasons. Some shut down only to return under a new name, perhaps in an attempt to confuse researchers and law enforcement agencies and sometimes to

[escape sanctions](#). Others decided to call it quits after obtaining enough funds to retire.



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In the case of Hunters International, it's still too early to tell what the gang's motivations are for shutting down, but there were signs as far back as April that point to a rebrand and transition to a group called World Leaks, according to Allan Liska, a threat intelligence analyst at cybersecurity firm Recorded Future.

"I think this is more of a 'cutting of ties' with the old infrastructure," said Liska, who has been tracking ransomware for years. "As far as releasing decryption keys, at this point they aren't likely to make any money from any Hunters' victims who are still out there, so they probably see it as a gesture that doesn't really cost them anything."

World Leaks group uses a new ransomware software and has a new site hosted elsewhere, but the people behind it may be the same, said Liska.

Liska said the reason for the gang going dark may be that “using the same technical infrastructure too long makes you more vulnerable to law enforcement,” referring to Hive, a ransomware gang that [was seized and shut down by the FBI](#) in 2023.

“Or, they got wind that law enforcement was closing in and decided to get ahead of them,” he said.

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UK plans to ban public sector organizations from paying ransomware hackers

Carly Page — 5:13 AM PST · January 14, 2025

U.K. public sector and critical infrastructure organizations could be banned from making ransom payments under new proposals from the U.K. government.

The U.K.'s Home Office [launched a consultation on Tuesday](#) that proposes a “targeted ban” on ransomware payments. Under the proposal, public sector bodies — including local councils, schools, and NHS trusts — would be banned from making payments to ransomware hackers, which the government says would “strike at the heart of the cybercriminal business model.”

This government proposal comes after a wave of cyberattacks targeting the U.K. public sector. The NHS last year [declared a “critical” incident](#) following a cyberattack on pathology lab provider Synnovis, which led to a massive data breach of sensitive patient data and months of disruption, including canceled operations and the diversion of emergency patients. According to [new data seen by Bloomberg](#), the cyberattack on Synnovis resulted in harm to dozens of patients, leading to long-term or permanent damage to their health in at least two cases.

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The newly outlined U.K. government proposals would also make it a criminal offense for critical infrastructure organizations, such as businesses in the energy and communications sectors, to make ransom payments in the event of a ransomware attack. U.K. government departments are already banned from paying ransomware gangs.

The U.K. proposals also detail a new mandatory reporting regime for ransomware incidents, which would require that cyberattack victims who are not covered by the ban report the incident to the government. Another proposal suggests a program aimed at preventing the payment of ransoms to sanctioned entities, which the government will have the power to block.

Security minister Dan Jarvis said: “With an estimated \$1 billion flowing to ransomware criminals globally in 2023, it is vital we act to protect national security as a key foundation upon which this government’s Plan for Change is built.

“These proposals help us meet the scale of the ransomware threat, hitting these criminal networks in their wallets and cutting off the key financial pipeline they rely upon to operate,” said Jarvis.



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According to data shared by the Home Office on Tuesday, the U.K.'s National Cyber Security Center managed 430 cyber incidents over the year ending August 2024, including 13 "nationally significant" ransomware incidents. These were carried out "largely by Russia-affiliated criminal gangs," the Home Office said, which continue to pose an "immediate and disruptive threat" to the U.K.'s critical national infrastructure.

The U.K.'s National Crime Agency took action against one of these gangs in October 2024, [unmasking an alleged affiliate of the prolific Russia-linked LockBit ransomware group](#). LockBit was linked to an earlier cyberattack on [NHS IT vendor Advanced](#).

The U.K. did not say if it plans to bring the measure before lawmakers in Parliament. The Home Office's consultation is set to end in April 2025.

In the United States, the federal government has long urged against paying ransom demands but has stopped short of imposing an outright national ban on ransom payments. However, [in October 2023](#), a U.S.-led alliance of more than 40 countries vowed not to pay ransoms to cybercriminals in a bid to starve the hackers from their source of income.

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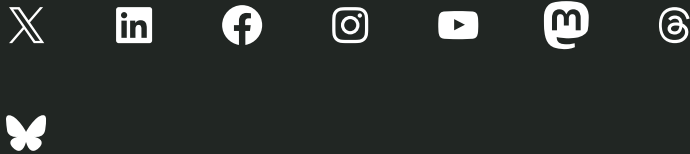
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